Iran: Political window for US escalation has closed

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Escalation in the US-Iran conflict by the end of 2026 is no longer the most likely outcome (30% odds, down from 60%), and the US is likely to focus on maintaining the status quo of blockades and sanctions (60%, up from 30%), while a limited deal between the US and Iran to reopen the strait remains unlikely (10%, unchanged).

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Three factors led to our change in views: the appointment of Stephen Miller—who has historically been more isolationist—as White House chief of staff, the decision not to strike late last week at the moment of greatest opportunity, and President Donald Trump’s comments downplaying escalation on 8 November ahead of a meeting with the Qatari prime minister.

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While the US has succeeded in increasing Middle East oil exports, ongoing Iranian attacks will reduce overall tanker capacity in 2027 and limit the US’s ability to sustain the current status quo.

Escalation is no longer likely. Based on evidence of increasing political constraints on Trump following last week’s midterm elections and the mounting opposition from inside the administration and the Republican Party to escalating the US military confrontation with Iran, we are shifting our scenarios. We now see a continued standoff as likely (60%, up from 30%) through the rest of 2026; the risk of escalation remains heightened but, given dwindling US interest, is no longer likely (30%, down from 60%). A deal remains very unlikely (10%), due to the lack of flexibility from either side in ongoing negotiations.

Pressure on Trump is to wait and let status quo play out. Trump remains open—even potentially eager—to try to break the ongoing stalemate with Iran through military force. However, a combination of factors has pushed him back toward maintaining the standoff status quo while exploring the possibility of a limited deal to reopen the strait.

Vice President JD Vance noted publicly that Iran was the reason for GOP losses in the midterms. In his new role, Miller is pushing Trump to move on, and frustrated GOP members of Congress are coming back to Washington threatening to upend Trump’s year-end agenda. With the exception of Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth, Trump’s inner circle of advisers all reportedly back both further diplomacy and a continuation of the standoff status quo. Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu, a consistent

advocate for tougher military action, is likely to be forced out of office (see: Opposition-led government is now likely , 6 November 2026). Trump himself has stated that escalation is no longer necessary, so long as negotiations continue.

The potential benefits of escalation would not outweigh the likely downsides. New strikes would trigger aggressive Iranian retaliation (see: Iran likely to retaliate aggressively if US attacks , 6 November 2026), and military options for effectively reducing Iran's capabilities through a short round of bombing are limited. There is little appetite on the US side for a more open-ended engagement, given concerns over diminished stockpiles of air interceptors. The odds of forcing additional concessions from Tehran through strikes on infrastructure are low, given Iran's demonstrated resilience to such pressure.

Efforts to reach a deal will continue, but a breakthrough looks remote. Despite active mediation by Qatar and other regional states, the possibility of a deal remains low. Iran is insisting the US make up-front concessions—including dropping the blockade and releasing frozen funds—before it ends its attacks on shipping. Iranian officials have agreed to discuss the country's nuclear program but remain unwilling to make concessions until after its demands are met. Despite the declining interest in escalation, the US is unlikely to bend to Iran's terms at this juncture.

US will ramp up pressure tactics. The announcement of a new blockade of Iran's overland trade routes ("Operation Iron Gate") signals a continued US interest in increasing economic pressure on top of sanctions and the blockade of Iran's seaborne trade, with the hope that the Islamic Republic's leaders retreat from their current negotiating position and agree to a deal more favorable to the US. Iran, however, is likely to resist such pressure, suggesting the near-term possibility of a deal remains low.

Escalation risk remains heightened, with US efforts in the strait likely to falter in 2027. Trump will retain the option to escalate, even if it no longer appears as attractive as it once did. While the US is managing to move more oil out of the Middle East, Iran's constant attacks on shipping remain an obstacle to returning the strait to its prewar status quo. In addition, the attacks' continued success—with Iran hitting one or two ships every day—will likely constrain shipping capacity in early 2027, forcing down flows and putting more pressure on the US to resolve the conflict, including (potentially) by military force.

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